A FACT SHEET FOR MONTANANS WHO WANT A REAL CHECK ON TRUMP

So you don't want a Trump Republican as your senator.

Here's what a vote for Seth Bodnar can — and can't — deliver.

Seth Bodnar says plenty that anti-Trump Montanans want to hear. He calls the tariffs "nonsensical."[3] He has condemned a "masked, untrained, unaccountable paramilitary force" in our cities.[4] But in the U.S. Senate, **criticism is not a check on power.** Power comes from a majority, a committee seat, and a gavel. Bodnar has pledged away the one thing that gets you all three.

THE PLEDGE

Bodnar has pledged **not to caucus with either party**.[1] His biggest outside backer, the Manchin-founded Independent Leadership Council's PAC, has reported about **$1.8 million** supporting him. It only backs candidates who make that pledge.[2]

What you're counting on vs. what a no-caucus senator can deliver

WHAT ANTI-TRUMP VOTERS WANT	BODNAR	WHY
Take the Senate majority away from Trump's party	❌ No	A senator who won't join the Democratic caucus doesn't count toward a Democratic majority. In 2001, a single senator, Jim Jeffords, flipped control of the entire Senate. He could only do it because he joined a caucus.[5]
Replace Trump-aligned leadership and control what gets a vote	❌ No	The majority leader is chosen by the majority party's caucus, and the majority leader decides what reaches the floor. Outside every caucus, Bodnar gets no vote on who leads.
Investigate and subpoena the administration	❌ No	Investigations and subpoenas are run by committee chairs. Chairs come from the majority caucus.
Use the power of the purse to stop unlawful actions	❌ No	Funding limits and "no money for X" provisions are written in the Appropriations Committee. Seats on it are handed out through the party caucuses.
Rein in ICE abuses	⚠️ Words only	He says he'd "legislate accountability."[4] But legislation is written in committee, and he'd have no committee seat to write it from.
Convict Trump if the House impeaches	⚠️ Not committed	The House impeaches, then the Senate holds the trial; conviction takes 67 votes.[12] We found no public commitment from Bodnar to vote to convict.
Vote "no" on bad bills and nominees	✅ Yes	Every senator gets a vote. This is the part he *can* do. But it comes at the very end of the process, and only on what the majority chooses to bring up.

❌ = structurally out of reach without a caucus · ⚠️ = said but no commitment or no means to deliver · ✅ = within reach. Numbers refer to sources on the back.

Where bills actually live or die

~16,500	Most	~1–2%
bills introduced in the last full Congress (2023–24)	never get a committee vote	became law (about 274)[6]

Committees decide which bills move, write the actual language, and attach the money. A senator with no committee seat only sees the final step: a yes-or-no vote on whatever survived.

WHAT A NO-CAUCUS SENATOR CAN DO

- Vote yes/no on what reaches the floor
- Give speeches and press conferences
- Place "holds" and object to fast-tracking
- Force votes on a few special resolutions (e.g., war powers)

WHAT A NO-CAUCUS SENATOR GIVES UP

- Committee seats, where bill language is written
- A say in who leads and what reaches the floor
- A role in deciding which party controls the Senate
- Party-run "hotlines" that clear most bipartisan bills
- Leverage: a vote promised never to be traded can't be traded for Montana

Montana's wins came from seats at the table (whatever you think of the senator)

CHAIR, SENATE VETERANS' AFFAIRS

Tester: PACT Act (2022)

The biggest expansion of care for toxic-exposed veterans in decades. It passed the Senate 86–11.[7]

CHAIR, DEFENSE APPROPRIATIONS SUBCOMMITTEE

Tester: Malmstrom and the Montana Guard

A gavel over nearly all defense spending meant real clout for Great Falls.[8]

MEMBER, HOUSE APPROPRIATIONS

Zinke: about $35M for western Montana (FY2026)

Including $10M for the Noxon Bridge and $10M for Seeley Lake's wastewater plant.[9]

BIPARTISAN PARTNER AND PARTY UC PROCESS

Sheehy: aerial firefighting law (2025)

He teamed up with a Democrat and cleared the Senate by unanimous consent.[10]

The last time a senator tried this

In 1953, Oregon's Wayne Morse left the Republican Party and refused to join either side. He was **stripped of his seats on Armed Services and Labor** and left with the D.C. and Public Works committees. When he forced a floor vote to get his seats back, **7 senators** backed him. He got his choice of committees back only in 1955, **after he joined the Democrats.**[11]

Bodnar says he can "negotiate for committee positions like any other senator."[1] A political scientist put it plainly: not caucusing with either party is "not something we've seen in modern times."[13]

"But couldn't he be the swing vote?" A swing vote is powerful when it can be traded. Jeffords traded his caucus membership for a Democratic majority. Bodnar has promised in advance never to make that trade, and his biggest backer requires the promise. That's leverage given away before he's sworn in.

The bottom line

Stopping Trump's agenda takes more than a "no" at the finish line. It takes a majority, a committee seat, and a gavel.

Ask Seth Bodnar: if your vote decides the Senate majority, will you give it to the party that will hold Trump accountable? So far, his pledge says no.

Numbered sources are listed on the next page.

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Sources and notes

1. Daily Montanan, "Bodnar announces independent campaign for U.S. Senate," Mar. 4, 2026; Hungry Horse News, "Bodnar stumps in Kalispell, commits to independence," Jul. 22, 2026; Newsweek, "Inside Seth Bodnar's Montana Senate Race...," 2026.
2. Montana Public Radio, "Interest group money rolls in to Montana's congressional races," Sep. 18, 2026; CNN, "Joe Manchin reenters the political orbit with a new independent experiment," Jul. 24, 2026.
3. KTVQ/KXLF, "Montana U.S. Senate hopeful Seth Bodnar talks tariffs, war and running without a party," 2026.
4. Daily Montanan, "Debate between US Senate candidates tips scales for audience members," Sep. 22, 2026.
5. U.S. Senate Historical Office, "Tom Daschle" (senate.gov); PBS NewsHour, Jeffords coverage, May 23–24, 2001.
6. Post Independent, citing GovTrack.us statistics for the 118th Congress (2023–24).
7. Senate Veterans' Affairs Committee press releases, June and August 2022 (veterans.senate.gov).
8. Defense News, "Sen. Jon Tester takes defense appropriations gavel," Feb. 12, 2021.
9. Office of Rep. Ryan Zinke press releases, Jan. 22 and Feb. 3, 2026 (zinke.house.gov).
10. Office of Sen. Tim Sheehy, Apr. 8, 2025 (sheehy.senate.gov); Bozeman Daily Chronicle, 2025.
11. U.S. Senate Historical Office, "Independent Fights" and "Wayne Morse" (senate.gov).
12. U.S. Constitution, Art. I, §2, cl. 5 and §3, cl. 6.
13. MSU Exponent, "Bodnar's unconventional Senate campaign takes shape, questions linger about his chances," 2026.

Notes on wording

- **"Impeach" vs. "convict."** The House impeaches; the Senate tries the case. A senator's role is the vote to convict, which takes two-thirds of senators present.
- **Committee seats.** No Senate rule bars a non-caucusing senator from committees. But seats are allocated through the two party conferences. The only modern attempt (Morse, 1953) ended with him losing his major committees.
- **Bill statistics.** Counts vary by source and by when they're measured. We use the full-Congress figure for 2023–24.
- **Impeachment position.** "No public commitment found" reflects a review of news coverage and candidate statements through Oct. 11, 2026. If Bodnar commits publicly, this row should be updated.

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